qualities of the sovereign’; because of their ‘good sense and propriety of conduct’ Akbar, too, was pleased with them. But while affairs of state continued, Akbar also sent a message to Fatehpur Sikri to fill the Anuptalao tank to the brim with silver and bronze coins to be distributed to the deserving and the wise. It would take a full three years to empty the tank of its coins and, in that time, the tenor of the wise men and the merit of the deserving would have changed the fabric of Mughal thought forever.

♦

In 1578, a fleet of three vessels set sail from Lisbon, carrying a blessed and exalted cargo. Travelling in the uneasy company of Christian relics, including the bones of one Saint Boniface, was a group of missionaries. Of the fourteen missionaries on the ships one would die of poison at the hands of the ‘pagan Japanese’, one was decapitated by ‘the natives’ of the island of Java, and a third man, twenty-eight-year-old Rudolf Acquaviva, landed in Goa on 13 September, after years of austerity and grief and penance, and knelt to kiss the Indian soil in joy and gratitude. A year later, a great deal of commotion was created by the arrival in Goa of an ambassador from a most unexpected source—the Mughal court. The envoy, Abdullah, carried a letter from Akbar which read: ‘To the chief Padre, in the name of the Lord. I am sending Abdullah…with the request that you will send me two learned Fathers, and the books of the Law, especially the Gospel, that I may know the Law and its excellence. For I desire to know it…. And the Fathers may be sure that I shall receive them most courteously, and entertain them most handsomely. When I have learnt the Law sufficiently to appreciate its excellence, then may they depart at their pleasure, with an escort and honoured with abundant rewards.’ These words filled the Jesuits with almost uncontrollable joy and as for Acquaviva in particular, ‘I should like to describe the pleasure, nay the inordinate delight’, wrote the Jesuit Monserrate, ‘with which Rudolf received this commission…as though it were a direct divine command’. This summons brought within reach a most precious object—the soul of the Mughal Padshah. The emperor, it was believed, was ‘weary of the contradictions and absurdity of the Mullahs, the “Scribes” of Moslem law’ and informed about the Christian faith by Pietro Tavers, the Portuguese officer now in his employ in Bengal, was eager to learn more about their religion.

The Jesuits were arriving in Hindustan in the sixteenth century as the Portuguese crown sought to strengthen their presence in foreign lands.